How to get there

The site is accessible from Gaborone - Kanye road taking a left turn at Thusano Lefatsheng Research Center on to Mankgodi – Boatle road. It is also accessible from the Gaborone – Lobatse road by taking a right westerly turn at Boatle junction, 19 kilometres from Gaborone into the Boatle - Mankgodi road.

Some Rules

Mmamotshwane is a national monument managed by the Botswana National Museum in partnership with the Mogonye community and protected by the Monuments and Relics Act (2001). Adherence to some basic rules will ensure the continued protection of this unique heritage:

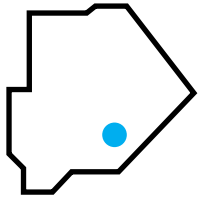
- Use the designated parking lot.
- Report to the custodian's office and complete the visitors' book.
- Do not remove, touch or interfere with any artifacts, plants or any other feature.
- Cooperate with the custodians.
- Take all your litter away with you.

PLEASE NOTE:
Researchers and commercial photographers should contact the Botswana National Museum for permission.









Designation: Natural
Area: approx. 3.6km²
Adoption priorities:
visitor interpretation centre, field assistants, signage, trails

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
Private Bag 00114 Gaborone, Botswana
Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

MOGONYE
gorge

BOTSWANA national museum

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

MG201511

Natural Heritage Site **Cultural Heritage Site**

MOGONYE/MMAMOTSHWANE GORGE

Mmamotshwane Gorge is the main one of the seven gorges found around Mogonye Village. Mogonye village is about 31 kilometres from Gaborone. It is siuated in the geographical position 24° 49'54.7' south, and 25° 42' 32.5' east. Mmamotshwane gorge is a natural site which contains areas of scenic beauty at the foot of the Mmamotshwane Hills. It is located about 5.5km south of Mogonye village along the Southern and South - east District boundary line. The gorge is alive with permanent water spring that fluctuate with the changing yearly seasons and amount of rainfall. It is also a source of water for domestic use and livestock.

Cultural Heritage

The people of Mogonye settled in the area around 18th century after migrating from Lehurutshe and Motswedi villages in South Africa due to wars between the Boers and the Ndebele. Agricultural land became a problem after the Bahurutshe of Bapoane from Otse joined those who were already at Mogonye wa Kgophu and some were forced to settle next to the gorge.

Metsimaswaane river divides the two settements within the landscape namely Mogonye boseja and Mogonye wa Kgophu Ya Ga Marete, which is the spring that the settlement identifies with and attaches some value to. Halfway up the Mmamotshwane hill is a site which constitutes the remains of a small stonewalled prehistoric village.Another site also found in the hills is the Dinkgwana archaeological site which has artifacts such as pottery and beads. It is said to be lefelo la badimo- a sacred ancestral place and people are scared to go into that site.





Natural Heritage

The gorge remains the only one known in the South-eastern part of Botswana. It has waterfalls, pools, highly dense vegetation and a high concentration of nettle trees that cover a wide area on the western side of the gorge.

It is believed to have been crafted by a long history of erosion by water flowing along the weakest line of the hills that was created by the movement of the earth known as tectonic movement. This resulted in intensive faulting and jointing. Water falls and pools supporting different plant and small animal species are found at the site.

The vegetation is typically shrub savannah that is characterised by slightly denser and taller trees than in the sand veld further west. The dominant trees are Mosetlha (Weeping Wattle), Mosu (Umbrella thorn), Mogonono (Silver Terminalia) and Bofitlha (Ferns).



The community treats the gorge as a sacred place because of the fern that is found at a place they call Ko Puleng. This fern is believed to be "the breath" of the gorge and removing it from it's original place means ending the life of the gorge. Thus they believe that from time immemorial, the fern has never been plucked off and has remained sacred.